



The port of Vicksburg

Steamboats had made Vicksburg a major trading center. A Confederate stronghold controlling traffic on the Mississippi River, the city was an essential strategic target of Union campaigns in the Western Theater.

Preliminary moves

On the night of April 16, 1863, Porter's gunboats made their bold dash past Vicksburg. One transport was sunk and the enemy scored 68 hits on the fleet overall, but the fast current and the element of surprise worked to Porter's favor. A few nights later, Porter got most of the rest of his fleet past. Meanwhile, Grant moved his army overland to the crossing point of Hard Times, and stood ready to transport his men across the river.